

Consider Owls

by Tanja Osswald



When you put on these mittens, owls open their eyes. The pattern is worked using back loop only slip stitches.

Special thanks to Waltraud for proofreading and for suggesting the pattern name, to Janine for testing and to Bethan for testing, proofreading and language advice!

Size

The mittens are about 19 cm (7.5 in) long unstretched. With wear, the model stretched out and shortened to about 16 cm (6.5 in). They are unstretched 5.5 cm (2.2 inches) wide (folded flat). Width can be adjusted. The mittens have to be worn with negative ease to open up the eyes of the owls. My model mittens have about 5 cm (2 inches) of negative ease.

Material

- ca. 40 g of Hedgehog Fibers Sock in the colorway "cinder" (140 m /155 yards)
- 3.5 mm crochet hook
- darning needle for seaming

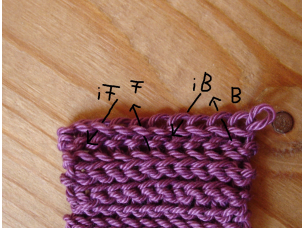
Note: The finished model weighs 29 g. Because everyone crochets slightly differently, it would be wise to plan a few grams extra, in particular if you substitute the yarn.

Gauge

About 24 sts in 10 cm (4 in), using back loop only slip stitches. Due to stretchiness of the pattern, height gauge is hard to determine.

Abbreviations

I use David Burchall's terminology in naming the slip stitch.



- st: stitch
- sts: stitches
- ch: chain
- B: slip stitch into the back loop (see also page 4)
- cf_1 (cf_2 , cf_3): cable front (move the working yarn around the first (second, third) strand with the yarn in front), see also page 5.
- cb_1 (cb_2 , cb_3): cable behind (move the working yarn around the first (second, third) strand with the yarn in back), see also page 5.

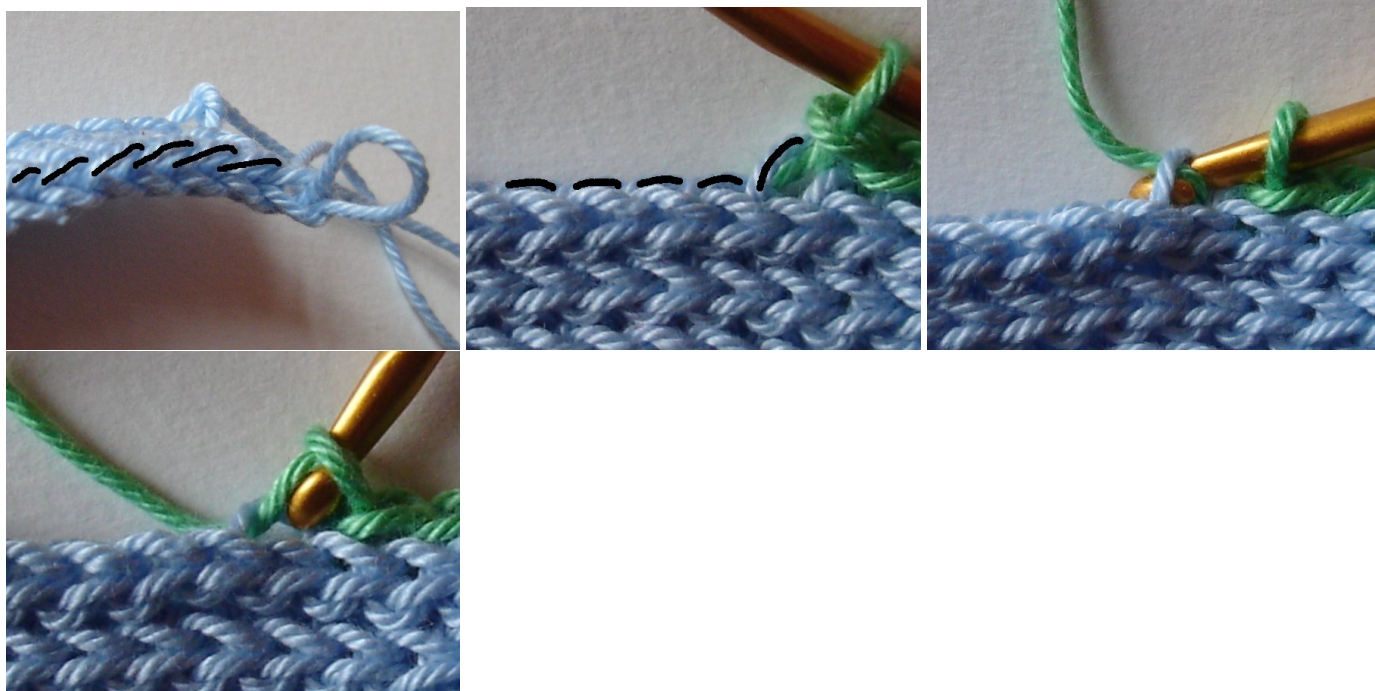
A note on turning chains: Turning chains are not necessary in slip stitch patterns. In this pattern, they are recommended because they promote stretchiness.

Stitch Tutorial

In case you are new to slip stitch crochet: Before you start on the pattern, take some non-splitty yarn that is easy to rip, choose a pointy smooth hook that is about 2 mm larger than the one you'd normally use and practice the basic stitch. Try to have as little tension as possible (that works for most people). In particular, if you hold the yarn by wrapping it several times around your index finger, try to change to a way without the extra wraps, so the yarn can flow through your fingers.

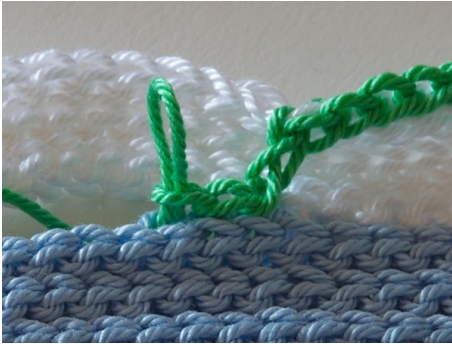
B

Insert the hook from the front into the back loop, yarn over, draw hook through all loops.



Techniques

Cable front (cf)



To cable in front of a strand (abbreviated cf, with the number of the strand indicated by an index) take your current row (green in the picture) across the strand, keeping it in front.

I don't differentiate whether the cabling goes upwards or downwards - that direction should be clear by the strand to twist around.

Cable behind (cb)



To cable behind a strand (abbreviated cb, with the number of the strand indicated by an index) take your current row (green in the picture) across the strand, keeping it to the back. You have to take the hook out of the live loop to put it into the back. As well, you have to take the working yarn along through the buttonhole. Be careful to carry your working yarn along to the right, over the stitches just made, so you can untrap it in the return row.

I don't differentiate whether the cabling goes upwards or downwards - that direction should be clear by the strand to twist around.

Horizontal four-stranded owl cable



A horizontal cable is worked by making the strands of the cable one after the other. Each strand is crocheted around the ones before. Thus, the first two strands are rather simple, the third and fourth strand need some concentration. I call the last row before the cable (grey in the picture) the base row.

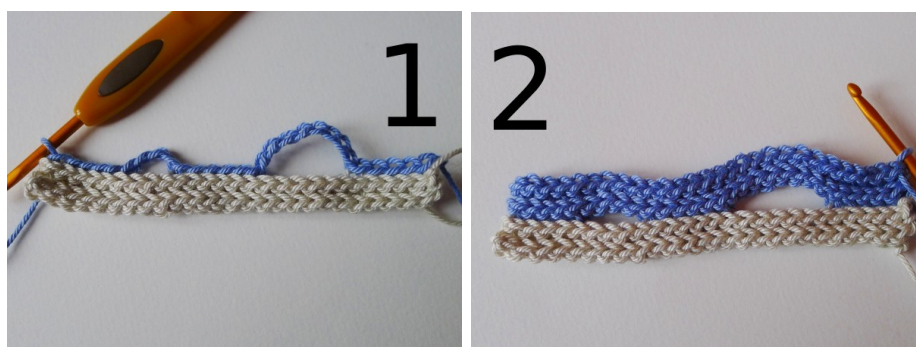
Throughout the whole tutorial, no stitch counts are given, as the exact numbers differ with the pattern.

For the second to fourth strand, be careful to have the working yarn follow along on the right, so it can get untrapped on each return row.

Please note that this tutorial shows the sequence of braiding for the right mitten. The left mitten has some cablings inverted.

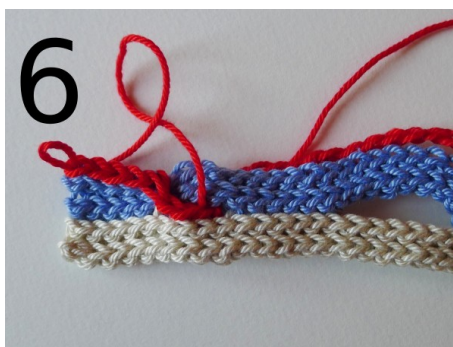
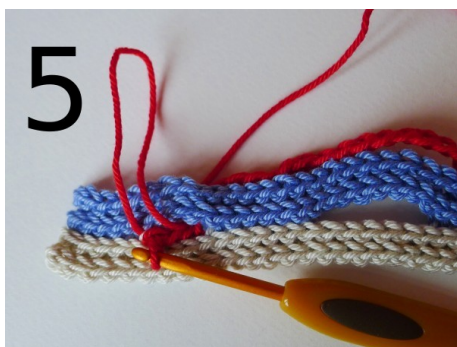
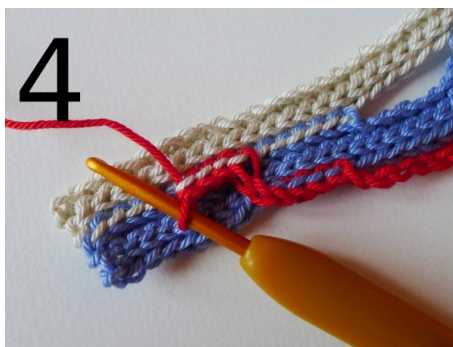
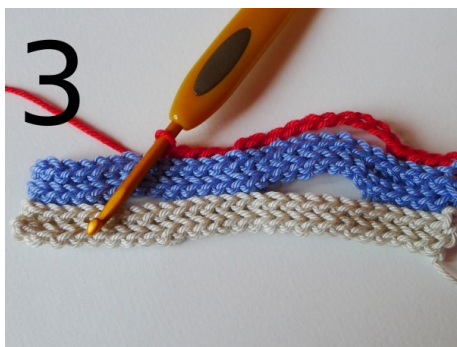
Strand 1: The first strand (blue) is worked as if you were making buttonholes (1). To have some ease for braiding, in the first part some more stitches are chained than skipped.

Work the rest of the strand without further shaping (2).



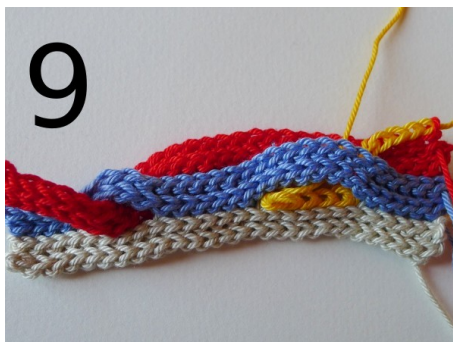
Strand 2: The second strand (red) is worked around the first. Work the first sts into the last row of the first strand. Ch some (all stitch numbers are given in the pattern), skip some, B some, $cb_1(4)$, B into the skipped sts of the base row, $cf_1(5)$. Work the rest of the row into the last row of the first strand (6). (Please note that picture 4 shows the backside of the work.) When you turn, take the hook out of the stitch, put the yarn to the back and reinsert the hook, so the yarn lies along the row just made. Do this for all odd rows in the rest of the braid.

Work the rest of the strand without further shaping (7), following the first row of this strand through the bottonhole each time.



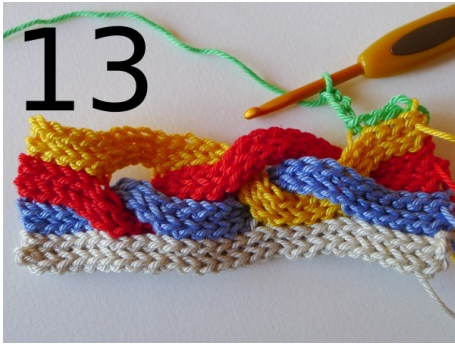
Strand 3: The third strand (yellow) is started on top of the second strand. B some (8), ch 2, cf_2 , cb_1 , work into the stitches of the base row (9), ch 2, cf_1 , cb_2 , B into the last row of the second strand (10), ch some, skip the small cabling below, work the rest of the row into the last row of the second strand (11).

Work the rest of the strand without further shaping (12), following the first row of this strand through the bottomhole each time.



Strand 4: The fourth strand (green) is started on top of the third strand. B some, ch 3 (13), cf_2 , B into the open sts of the first strand, ch 3, cb_2 , B into the last row of the third strand (14), cf_3 , B into the open sts of the first strand (15), cb_3 , work the rest of the row into the last row of the third strand (16).

Work the rest of the strand without further shaping (17).



After you are done with the braid, work the next row into the side loops of the strands as they appear: fourth strand (18), second strand (19), fourth strand (20), third strand (21), fourth strand (22). The row you work into has the V of each stitch pointing to the left, see picture 19 for a close-up. The number of stitches to work into in each strand is given in the pattern.



Short Rows

Short rows sometimes have the reputation of being complicated. This is undeserved. Remember when you once picked up your work in progress the wrong way and continued back along the row instead of finishing it? That's what you do on purpose with short rows. They can be used for visual effect only or for shaping, in particular for garments.

In the photos, I worked in B only. The short row is worked in pink.



For a short row, stop before the end of the row, make a chain, turn and work back (pink in the picture). Some stitches of the row below (white in the picture) are left unworked (2). When the pattern tells you to, work to the end of the short row (3) and then continue along the unworked stitches.

To avoid holes, for the first stitch after the short row, insert the hook first into the turning chain of the short row (4) and then into the stitch (5). Yarn over and pull through all three loops.

Continue along the unworked stitches (6).



Invisible Seam

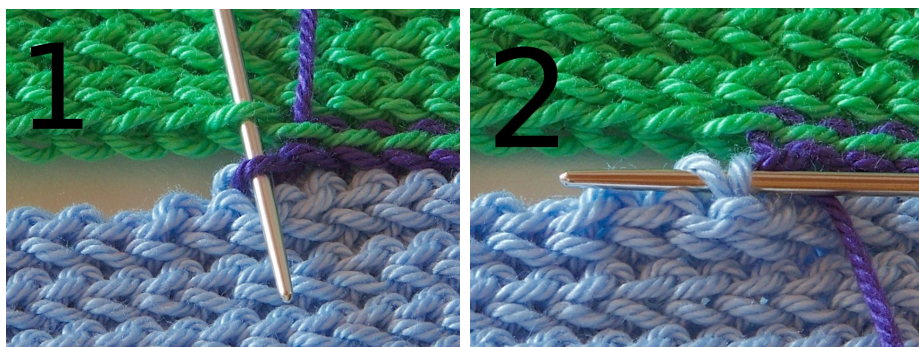
To make an invisible seam, you mimic a back loop stitch with your needle. It takes longer than a crocheted seam but it is invisible. Below, you see photos of the seam from the front (left picture) and from the back (right picture).



Do not fasten off before making the seam, skip the turning chain and then cut the yarn generously (five times the length of the seam plus some extra for sewing in the end) and thread it into a darning needle.

Place mitten before you. The starting tail should be on the bottom on the left and the live loop and sewing needle should be on the top on the right. Fold up the bottom edge (blue) and fold down the top edge (green) so that they form a tube.

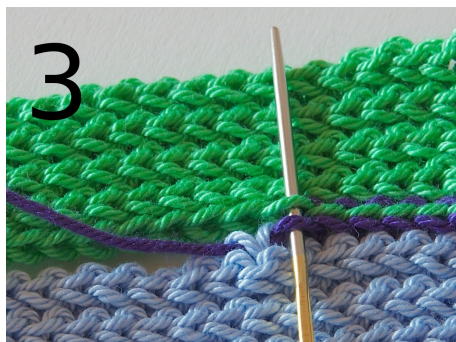
For starting, insert the needle through the loop of the live stitch. Work step 2 through the first two back bumps in the row and then go back through the live stitch, leaving the loop you have just made loose so that you can see which one it is. Continue with step 1-3 until the end.



Step 1: Insert the needle from the top through the next back loop (green) and further down through the loose loop formed by the last step (purple) (1). Gently pull the loose loop tight while the needle is still in the loops. Pull needle through.

Step 2: Insert the needle from the front through the back bump used last, then from the back through the next (blue) (2). Pull needle through, leaving the loop loose.

Step 3: Go up through the loose purple loop and the green loop used in step 1 (3). Gently pull the loose loop tight but make sure the horizontal loop you are forming stays loose for now.



Pattern

The mittens are worked in rows of B, from side to side. Each row is turned with a chain, to ensure stretchiness. The turning chains are not mentioned in the pattern below, you have to add them on your own.

As it is a rib patten, the mittens are not blocked.

Note: To make the invisible seam work, do *not* work your first row into the back bumps of the beginning chains but into the back loops, like regular B stitches.

Right Mitten

Start with 50 chains plus one turning chain. Work each row in B until 2 ribs are formed (4 rows, counting the chains as a row).

Now start with the cable (see also p. 6ff).

Strand 1: B 5, ch 8, skip 6, B 6, ch 4, skip 4, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping.

Strand 2: B 4, ch 10, skip 10, B 5, cb₁, B 4 into the base row, cf₁, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonhole.

Strand 3: B 4, ch 2, cf₂, cb₁, B 6 into the base row, ch 2, cf₁, cb₂, B 5, ch 4, skip 4 over the cabling below, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonholes.

Strand 4: B 4, ch 3, cf₂, B 4 into the first strand (leaving 3 sts open before and after), ch 3, cb₂, B 5 into the third strand, cf₃, B 4 into the first strand, cb₃, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonholes.

The next row is worked across the top of the cables. B 5, B 6 into the second strand (10 sts, skip the first and last 2 sts), B 6 into strand 4 (skip the first 8 unworked sts of strand 4), B 4 into the third strand, B 29 into the fourth strand (= 50 sts).

Work 5 more rows (= 3 ribs).

Now the thumb is worked in short rows.

Row 1: B 22

Row 2: B 12

Row 3: B 10

Row 4: B 10

Row 5: B 8

Row 6: B 8

Row 7: B 6

Row 8: B 6

Row 9: B 7

Row 10: B 7

Row 11: B 9

Row 12: B 9

Row 13: B 11

Row 14: B 11, fold the thumb to a tube, B 10
into the open sts of Row 1 of the thumb
(= 21 sts)

B in next row working down mitt and thumb and mitt again to make one straight row (= 50 sts). Continue in B until 9 ribs are formed or until the piece goes around your hand when slightly stretched. Work one more row, leaving open the last st. Your last stitch should be at the opposite end of the yarn tail from the beginning. Cut the yarn generously, at least five times as long as your last row. Seam the last row to the beginning chain invisibly (p. 12).

Left Mitten

The left mitten is worked in a similar way to the right one, starting with the thumb and reversing some of the cables in the owls so they are symmetrical.

Start with 50 chains plus one turning chain. Work each row in B until 2 ribs are formed (4 rows, counting the chains as a row).

Now, work the thumb.

Row 1: B 21

Row 2: B 11

Row 3: B 9

Row 4: B 9

Row 5: B 7

Row 6: B 7

Row 7: B 6

Row 8: B 6

Row 9: B 8

Row 10: B 8

Row 11: B 10

Row 12: B 10

Row 13: B 12

Row 14: B 12, fold the thumb to a tube, B 10
into the open sts of Row 1 of the thumb
(= 22 sts)

Continue over all 50 sts and work 6 more rows (= 3 ribs). Now, the cables are started. Changes to the right mitten occur in the third strand and are marked **bold**.

Strand 1: B 5, ch 8, skip 6, B 6 ch 4, skip 4, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping.

Strand 2: B 4, ch 10, skip 10, B 5, cb₁, B 4 into the base row, cf₁, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonhole.

Strand 3: B 4, ch 2, **cb**₂, cb₁, B 6 into the base row, ch 2, cf₁, **cf**₂, B 5, ch 4, skip 4 over the cabling below, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonholes.

Strand 4: B 4, ch 3, cf₂, B 4 into the first strand (leaving 3 sts open before and after), ch 3, cb₂, B 5 into the third strand, cf₃, B 4 into the first strand, cb₃, B 29

Work three more rows without further shaping, following the row through the buttonholes.

The next row is worked across the top of the cables. B 5, B 6 into the second strand (10 sts, skip the first and last 2 sts), B 6 into strand 4 (skip the first 8 unworked sts of strand 4), B 4 into the third strand, B 29 into the fourth strand (= 50 sts).

Continue in B until 9 more ribs are formed or until the piece goes around your hand when slightly stretched. Work one more row, leaving open the last st. Your last stitch should be at the opposite end of the yarn tail from the beginning. Cut the yarn generously, at least five times as long as your last row. Seam the last row to the beginning chain invisibly (p. 12).

Sizing

Width

The rows given are for a medium wrist. You can provisionally close the seam by slip stitching it together. Slip it over your hand and see whether it feels good. To adjust the width, work an even number of rows more or less.

Length

To make the mittens longer or shorter, start with more or less chains. Leave at least three stitches on either side of the cables.